PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY MARK SCHEME

Best Guess Mock Exam 10: Opposition and Civil Rights Acts (1957–60)

Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75 (1HI0/33)

Question 1: Inference from Source A (4 Marks)

Target: AO3 (4 marks). Award 1 mark for each valid inference, up to 2. Award 1 mark for each corresponding quote/detail, up to 2.

Sample Acceptable Inferences (the methods used by White Citizens' Councils to oppose civil rights in the 1950s):

• **Inference 1:** White Citizens' Councils used coordinated economic retaliation to punish anyone supporting integration.
- *Detail from source:* "If any local merchant employs integrationists, we must withdraw our business immediately. If any landlord rents to those who support integration, they must be evicted."

• **Inference 2:** Opponents of civil rights framed integration as an external, hostile plot against Southern culture.
- *Detail from source:* "Economic non-cooperation is our most powerful peaceful weapon to defeat this Northern conspiracy against our traditions."

Question 2: Causal Explanation (12 Marks)

Target: AO1/AO2 (12 marks). Level 4 (10–12 marks): An analytical explanation showing a line of reasoning with clear links to the outcome, supported by accurate, detailed knowledge.

"One reason why opposition to the civil rights movement was successful in delaying progress in the years 1954–60 was the unified political defiance of Southern leaders." In 1956, 101 Southern members of Congress signed the **Southern Manifesto**, which accused the Supreme Court of abusing its power in the Brown ruling and urged states to resist desegregation. *Therefore, this political defiance legitimized state-level resistance, encouraging Southern governors to pass laws closing public schools rather than desegregating them.*

"A second reason why opposition to the civil rights movement was successful in delaying progress was the use of violence and physical intimidation." The **KKK** experienced a revival, using bombings, beatings, and threats of violence against civil rights activists. For example, during the Montgomery Bus Boycott, the homes of leaders were bombed, and local registrars used poll taxes and literacy tests backed by economic threats to keep Black voter registration extremely low. *Therefore, this climate of terror and systemic disenfranchisement intimidated many Black citizens, successfully slowing the growth of grassroots campaigns.*

"A third reason why opposition to the civil rights movement was successful in delaying progress was the systemic economic intimidation enforced by the **White Citizens' Councils**." Formed in 1954 in response to the Brown ruling, these councils consisted of prominent white local businessmen, bankers, and politicians. They targeted civil rights supporters by evicting Black tenants, denying bank loans and mortgages to Black buyers, and firing Black workers who signed school integration petitions. *Therefore, this economic warfare delayed progress because it threatened the direct livelihood of Black families, making the cost of participation in civil rights activism financially ruinous for many ordinary citizens.*

Question 3(a): Source Utility (8 Marks)

Target: AO3 (8 marks). Assess content utility, verify with contextual knowledge, and evaluate provenance reliability and limitations for BOTH sources.

Source B is highly useful for demonstrating the politically organized, constitutional nature of Southern resistance. Southern congressmen assert that the Supreme Court's desegregation rulings are a "clear abuse of judicial power" and pledge to use "all lawful means to bring about a reversal". This is supported by my knowledge that 101 Southern politicians signed the Southern Manifesto in 1956, which encouraged states to resist desegregation (known as 'Massive Resistance'), showing how opposition was led by the political elite. The provenance of the Southern Manifesto increases its usefulness because it is an official, public declaration signed by nearly all Southern members of Congress. While it is a piece of political propaganda designed to rally Southern voters and pressure the courts, it is highly useful for showing how desegregation was legally and politically challenged at the highest levels of government.

Source C is highly useful for showing the local, economic methods of opposition used by segregationists. The speaker boasts that "we hold the economic power" and threatens Black citizens with being "without jobs, without credit... and without homes" if they demand integration. This content's utility is supported by my knowledge that White Citizens Councils were formed throughout the South in the mid-1950s, using economic coercion, firings, and mortgage foreclosures to ruin civil rights activists financially, which verifies the speaker's threats. The provenance of a speech at a public segregationist rally in 1956 makes it useful for revealing the public rhetoric, intimidation tactics, and confidence of local segregationist organizations. While it is a highly partisan and aggressive speech designed to mobilize opposition and terrorize Black activists, it is very useful for capturing the grassroots economic warfare used to defend segregation.

Question 3(b): Difference Between Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Identify the main difference of view, supported by details from both interpretations.

The main difference is that Interpretation 1 argues that the opposition to civil rights was highly successful, stating that it **"effectively delayed integration for years"** through a combination of political resistance and economic terror. In contrast, Interpretation 2 argues that the opposition ultimately failed to halt progress, stating that its extreme resistance **"actually backfired"** and forced the federal government to pass the Civil Rights Acts of 1957 and 1960.

Question 3(c): Reason for Difference in Interpretations (4 Marks)

Target: AO4 (4 marks). Explain how the historians may have relied on different sources to reach their views.

The interpretations differ because the historians have given weight to different sources. Interpretation 1 is supported by Source C, which details how White Citizens Councils threatened to leave Black citizens "without jobs" and "without homes", leading to the view that opposition was **"highly organized and politically entrenched, successfully stalling desegregation"**. Conversely, Interpretation 2 is supported by Source B, which show that despite the Southern politicians promising to resist "judicial power", the Federal government was forced to intervene, leading to the view that the opposition **"ultimately failed to halt civil rights progress"**.

Question 3(d): Evaluation of Interpretation (16 Marks + 4 SPaG)

Target: AO4 (16 marks) + SPaG (4 marks). Level 4 (13–16 marks): Balanced discussion analyzing both interpretations with sustained contextual knowledge, leading to a justified judgment.

I agree to a large extent with Interpretation 1 that the opposition was highly effective in stalling progress. White Citizens Councils grew to over **250,000** members, unleashing economic terror that devastated Black activists' livelihoods. The **KKK** was revived, committing bombings and lynchings. Southern states implemented 'Massive Resistance', passing laws to close integrated schools. As a result, by 1960, less than **1%** of Southern Black students academic integration was realized. This supports Interpretation 1's view that local opposition was **"highly organized and politically entrenched"** and **"effectively delayed integration for years"**.

However, Interpretation 2 is also valid in noting that opposition backfired politically. The extreme obstruction by Southern leaders forced a reluctant President **Eisenhower** to introduce the **1957 Civil Rights Act**, the first federal civil rights legislation since Reconstruction, followed by the **1960** Act. While these acts were politically weak and only raised Southern Black voter registration by **3%**, they established the crucial precedent of federal intervention. Defiance at Little Rock forced Eisenhower to deploy the **101st Airborne Division**, proving that local resistance could trigger federal military force, confirming Interpretation 2's view that opposition **"actually backfired"** and prompted **"federal voting rights protection"**.

Overall, while the political backlash (Interpretation 2) laid the legal groundwork for future intervention, Interpretation 1 is more convincing for the late 1950s. On the ground, the combination of state resistance, economic terror, and white violence successfully nullified federal rulings, ensuring that segregation remained the daily reality for the vast majority of Southern Black Americans.